

4 Grand Theft Longboat

Using Video Games and Medievalism to Teach Medieval History

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Introduction

The medieval past is an enduringly popular setting for video games. Between 1980 and 2013 over 600 games with medieval settings were released (Romera, Ojeda, and Velasco 2018). Such games span a variety of genres from action RPGs to grand strategy games and games including turn-based strategy and real-time tactics. This corpus of medieval games also encompasses the full chronological range of the Middle Ages, offering settings from Anglo-Saxon England to twelfth-century Palestine and fifteenth-century Bohemia. The perennial appeal of the medieval past as a setting for video games is matched by the frequency with which the Middle Ages is represented in other popular media such as films, TV shows, novels and comics (Ashton 2015). However, medieval history does not often form part of the syllabi taught to school pupils at GCSE and A level in the United Kingdom.¹ Thus when students arrive at university to begin an undergraduate degree in History their knowledge and understanding of the Middle Ages usually derives from popular media, rather than from formal study of the period.² This context was part of the inspiration for creating a module which I have run at third-year undergraduate level since 2013, as part of the BA in History offered at the University of Huddersfield.³ The module is entitled: ‘History and Myth: Writing and Re-writing the Middle Ages’. It entails analysis of both medieval narratives (those created during the Middle Ages) and modern medieval narratives (especially those in the form of video games, films and TV shows). The students draw on scholarship which emphasises the importance of interrogating not only the content of such narratives (both medieval and modern) but also the forms which they take and the processes by which they were created. This approach facilitates a better understanding of how and why individual narratives represent medieval people and events than a focus on simply assessing the accuracy of their content allows.

I devised ‘History and Myth’ as a replacement for a more traditional module covering late medieval English history which I had previously offered third-year students. I wanted to create a new module which

combined the study of medieval history and modern representations of the Middle Ages in a way that would be engaging for the students but also intellectually and pedagogically valid. Students taking this module draw on the ever-increasing wealth of Medievalism scholarship which explores representations of the Middle Ages in terms of standards, mores and preoccupations contemporary to the times in which they were made (e.g. D'Arcens 2014). We therefore examine the ways in which modern depictions of medieval events and people function as gauges for changing social attitudes or serve as expressions of particular ideological and political views (e.g. Elliott 2017). The title 'History and Myth' was chosen in the hope that it would intrigue and attract potential students, but its core methodologies do not entail positing a categorical divide between history (true) and myth (false). Instead the module encourages students to appreciate the commonalities between history and myth as discourses which tell stories about the past for particular purposes (Kapell and Elliott 2013, 359–69). A final and crucial motive was that I wanted to offer a different form of assessment from the more conventional essay, documentary analysis or oral presentation. Instead one of the assessment elements allows students to draw on their experiences of playing medieval video games, or watching films/TV set in the Middle Ages. Thus, as this chapter describes, students taking my module have the opportunity to devise and pitch their own original medieval video game. The intention of this exercise is partly to further their understanding of the processes by which medieval history has been and continues to be written. It is also designed to enhance their apprehension of how and why medieval people and events are depicted in popular media, and why the Middle Ages remains such a popular choice of setting.

History and Myth: Content and Assessment

After introducing the general aims and methodologies of the module in the first seminar, the weekly three-hour teaching sessions focus on a range of medieval topics. Most of the topics can be described as quintessentially medieval, in that they focus on well-known individuals, groups and themes. The nature and central concerns of the module require them to be topics for which there are surviving medieval narrative sources and of which there are modern popular culture representations. The syllabus has varied across the years, partly as a result of student requests to cover specific topics. Among the topics which have been included are Joan of Arc, Owain Glyn Dŵr, El Cid, the Borgias, the Mongols, Chivalry and Tournaments, Margery Kempe, Warfare and battles, the Crusades, the Gothic Middle Ages and Viking Women Warriors. We begin by exploring the primary source evidence in relation to secondary scholarship and historiographical trends within this. To give a specific example, the session on Robin Hood focuses on analysis of the earliest surviving medieval ballad

recounting his adventures: ‘Robin Hood and the Monk’, which was written down after 1450. Many historians have attempted to identify a ‘real’ Robin Hood whose exploits formed the inspiration for this and other late medieval ballads. However, our discussions focus instead on what the ballads tell us about the later medieval context in which they circulated orally and then were written down. Students consult and respond to the work of scholars such as R. H. Hilton, R. B. Dobson, J. Taylor and A. J. Pollard, who have drawn differing conclusions about the origins and audience for the ballads in the fifteenth century and their status as expressions of social commentary and protest (Hilton 1958; Dobson and Taylor 1976; Pollard 2004). The session then moves on to discuss post-medieval manifestations of Robin Hood and his legend, considering such issues as the significance of the shift of his social status from yeoman to dispossessed nobleman, the changing representation of Maid Marian and the inclusion of a black member of the Merry Men in several film and TV versions. In assessing why Robin Hood has been and continues to be such a popular subject within modern media the work of Stephen Knight is particularly valuable in its exploration of the innately appealing and thus entertaining qualities of the narrative and its characters (e.g. Knight 2003). Knight’s work also helps the students discern why Robin Hood’s legend and the versions of the Middle Ages which it conveys have been brought into the service of a range of interests and ideologies and the influence that this has had on his representation (Knight 2006). Thus, for every topic the students also consult Medievalism scholarship, to help them analyse modern representations of the Middle Ages in ways that avoid an emphasis on ‘accuracy’ and ‘inaccuracy’. Instead, when examining instances when such representations depart from established versions of events the students are directed to account for this by asking: Why have changes been made? To what ends? And with what resulting impact on the characterisation of individuals or the course of the narrative? (cf. Kapell and Elliott 2013, 8–9). The content and methodologies which we discuss in the seminars are designed to support the assessment exercises which students are required to complete.

The more conventional academic element of the assessment is a 2,000-word essay. Students choose one of four topics: Joan of Arc, Robin Hood, King Arthur or the Vikings. Their choice is constrained to these four in order to ensure that they are working on topics which have been widely represented in modern media, and about which there is a range of Medievalism scholarship upon which they can draw. They are set the question ‘How has/have Joan of Arc/Robin Hood/King Arthur/the Vikings been represented in modern media and for what purposes?’ The essay thus entails engaging with Medievalism as a field of study and as a methodology. Part of the objective here is to further develop students’ appreciation of modern representations of the Middle Ages as primary sources for the times in which they were made.⁴ The students are instructed to pick

three modern representations of their chosen topic in order to focus their argument. They are advised to consider issues such as the influence of, for example, genre, creators and audience on the ways in which individuals and events are depicted, as well as assessing the extent to which the versions of the Middle Ages represented in their chosen examples are inflected by modern concerns.

The essay is also designed to help prepare them for the second assessment element: a 10- minute oral pitch for a video game/film/TV series with a medieval setting or based on medieval individuals and events.⁵ Essentially, this element therefore directs the students to devise their own modern medieval narrative. Students are given a free hand in choosing a topic; their pitch can be based on any aspect of medieval history, from 500 to 1500, and they are encouraged to consider the Middle Ages in global terms rather than necessarily picking a Western European setting.⁶ They are assessed on the delivery of the pitch itself, which is presented to me and the rest of the cohort.⁷ They are also required to create and submit supporting materials: a powerpoint (or similar AV presentation) to accompany the pitch, and also a pitch bible which gives them the opportunity to develop and substantiate their idea at greater length than is possible in 10 minutes. The pitch bible may be cited for further detail during the presentation. Finally the students write a short reflective self-assessment of their pitch performance, which has to be submitted within 24 hours in order to ensure that it constitutes the students' immediate reactions to the experience. I take this self-assessment into account, alongside the other elements, when deciding their mark.⁸

The students are aware of the assessment strategy for this module when they make their third-year module choices during the second year. The nature and requirements of the pitch are introduced in detail at the very start of the module. The students are given plenty of guidance as to approach and form, which is recapped in subsequent sessions. The starting point for developing their pitch is to undertake some conventional research into their chosen topic, to establish the nature of surviving primary sources and familiarise themselves with academic debates revolving around their interpretation. They are told that their product can either be inspired by actual events/individuals or else can use a particular medieval period/place/event as a setting for their own plot. Or they can present a mixture of the two. If they wish it can be based, as far as possible, on the narrative presented by a particular medieval source or sources, or can follow the line of interpretation championed by a particular modern academic historian. But it does not have to be entirely faithful to either of these, or present an 'accurate', academically accepted account in terms of sequence of events, or cause and effect. Indeed, the more successful pitches often do not. A number of students have taken the pitch as an opportunity to explore the 'what ifs' of a particular event or the divergent strands of interpretation revolving around an individual's

reputation. Students can present a pitch which uses the medieval past to comment more or less explicitly on modern issues or concerns. They can also choose to present a medieval narrative or event in a modern setting. I introduce a range of possibilities to the students but emphasise that the precise nature of the product and what it does with the medieval past is up to them. Other guidance provided includes online resources which discuss how to prepare a real pitch of this nature (e.g. Dummies, n.d.; Atkinson 2010). They are also shown examples of previous student work, including, when possible, delivery of a pitch by one or two of the students who took the module the previous year. The students deliver a five-minute practice pitch to me and the whole group in the fifth week of teaching in order to establish the viability of the idea. The students are also given specific assessment criteria relating to the pitch element, in addition to the usual criteria we use for assessing third-year work.

When delivering their pitch, the content of the proposed product is important, but the students are warned not to dwell on simply relating the plot and to ensure that they spend time clearly establishing the nature of the product. In particular they must explain their choice of specific genre of video game/film/TV programme. They are required to explain the implications of presenting their topic in this form, for example, outlining the generic conventions which would determine aspects such as appearance and structure, and indicating how this determines their handling and presentation of individuals, events and themes. They must also discuss the ways in which form is also shaped by other factors such as the nature of the projected audience and the expectations which they will bring to the product. In fulfilling this aspect of the assessment brief students need to give examples of comparative video games/films/TV series which provide inspiration for theirs. Students can also cite negative examples of video games/films/TV series which they believe have represented the medieval past ineffectively or inauthentically. Finally the students are asked to think about the practicalities of making their product in terms of identifying and rationalising the choice of specific writers/directors, cast members/voice actors, producers/companies, as well as commenting on other aspects such as design, music, forms of marketing and so on. It is an opportunity for those with artistic and technological skills to employ these, but they are not given extra credit per se for producing their own art work or similar. Creative use can be made of existing images, clips, music, art work, etc. if properly credited. Before explaining the central objective of the pitch, it is necessary first to discuss the methodologies lying behind the conception of this form of assessment, which imbue it with intellectual value.

Underpinning Methodologies

The methodological considerations underpinning the module and its assessment strategy derive from broader conceptual issues revolving

around the definition of ‘History’ as both an academic subject and a discourse. From the start of the module I discuss with my students the necessity of approaching the recording of history as an act of interpretation, never simply an impartial relation of the ‘facts’.⁹ Due to the nature of my own research interests our starting point for this discussion are medieval chronicles, and historiographical developments in the appreciation and interrogation of these by modern scholars.¹⁰ Traditionally chronicles were viewed as repositories of information to be mined by later historians attempting to reconstruct past events in the most accurate way possible. This attitude was predicated on the belief that it was necessary to winnow the ‘factual’ content of a chronicle away from the ‘fictional’ rhetoric trappings within which the essentially ‘true’ elements had been expressed by the chronicle’s author. Matthew Kempshall describes this as an ‘extractive, one-dimensional approach’ and argues instead for the greater value of an approach which, rather than trying to exclude the fictional and rhetorical components of chronicles, seeks to understand their role within medieval historical methodologies and their status as ‘narrative strategies’ (Kempshall 2011, 3–4). He further argues that such an approach enhances our understanding of how medieval chronicles were read and comprehended at the time, noting that chronicle authors had to engage with and respond to audience expectations (Kempshall 2011, 4). Marcus Bull observes that recent scholarship on chronicles ‘has deepened our understanding of medieval historical works as situated cultural artefacts which articulated discourses that neither rigidly separated what we would term “history” and “fiction” nor hopelessly conflated them’ (Bull 2018, 49).

Among the scholarship exploring these issues which the students consider is Simon John’s survey of First Crusade chroniclers’ use of oral testimony. John is explicitly not concerned with trying to ascertain the historical accuracy of passages containing oral evidence and whether they can help us to understand what ‘really happened’ (John 2015, 264). Instead, he focuses his analysis on the ways in which chroniclers assessed and employed oral sources, and what this tells us about their perceptions of historical truth.¹¹ Thus, while those currently working on chronicles still pay careful attention to their contents, as well as exploring the context in which they were written, they increasingly focus analysis on the form of individual chronicles. The usefulness of theories and methodologies drawn from other disciplines is often highlighted. For example Bull’s recent conceptually rich study of crusade narratives contends that narratological concepts such as narrator and storyworld are very useful tools for understanding the role of so-called eyewitness evidence within these (Bull 2018).

Moreover, while medieval chronicle authors set out to narrate the truth, to relate what had actually happened, they also often had to narrate what *might* have happened (Kempshall 2011, 368). The limitations

of their sources, whether written or oral, could leave gaps, and it was deemed entirely acceptable to fill these with fiction. In this context fiction was understood as an aspect of rhetoric and was synonymous with hypothesis (Kempshall 2011, 350–1). As Kempshall puts it, for chroniclers, composing a fictional account entailed ‘the plausible reconstruction of events’ and was held to be distinct from inventing incidents or processes of cause and effect which could never have happened (Kempshall 2011, 350–1; Given-Wilson 2004, 3–5). This further highlights the redundancy of attempting to extract fictional components from chronicles.¹² In discussing these issues with the students I draw their attention to a clear overlapping of methodological interests between those working on medieval historical narratives and those working on modern medieval narratives. To this end I highlight Part I of Andrew Elliott’s *Remaking the Middle Ages* which provides a complementary exploration of the commonalities between the writing of academic history and the making of films. ‘After all’, as he observes, ‘both are working from a selected series of “known facts” to elaborate a believable narrative’ (Elliott 2010, 13; Kapell and Elliott 2013, 6–8; Chapman 2016, 7–8).

There are some scholars who go beyond recognising the value of the fictional elements of medieval historical narratives to advocate for the usefulness of fiction as a research technique for modern historians. Arguably the most important piece of required reading on the module is John Hatcher’s stimulating article ‘Fiction as History: The Black Death and Beyond’ (Hatcher 2012). This recounts the process by which he came to write his *The Black Death: An Intimate History of the Plague*, which presents an imaginative day by day re-creation of the impact of the original 1348 outbreak of the Black Death on the village of Walsham, in Suffolk (Hatcher 2008). This is based in part on surviving administrative and other evidence which had been previously studied and analysed in a more conventional manner by Hatcher and others. But in his preface to the book Hatcher states that he sets out on ‘the quest to uncover the hidden history of the mid-fourteenth century and provide new perspectives on what is already known’ (Hatcher 2008, xi). In order to achieve this, large chunks of the book constitute what he describes as ‘creative reconstructions, together with composed dialogue, and therefore are far closer to literary docudrama than conventional history’ (Hatcher 2008, xi). The article provides a more substantial rationale for *The Black Death*’s approach, partly as a response to scholarly reviews of the book. Within it Hatcher makes a clarion call for the use of fiction as a form of historical method: ‘This article explores a number of ways in which the use of style, imagination and straightforward invention of the type employed by the writers of fiction might assist in the writing of history; not merely by making it more attractive and accessible to more people but by advancing knowledge and understanding of the past’ (Hatcher 2012, 7). He further contends that ‘it is worth experimenting with the

selective use of the techniques of fiction to discover whether they have the capacity to assist in extending and deepening our knowledge of select parts of the past by opening up new perspectives and providing fruitful means of testing well-entrenched judgements and assumptions' (Hatcher 2012, 23).

Hatcher's article greatly influenced the conception of my module. His contentions and the scholarship on medieval chronicles described earlier help to frame the assessments in terms of the value of informed speculation as a means of 'filling in the gaps'. These gaps are left by the partial nature of historical sources; partial both in the sense being subjective and of being fragmentary. This provides the foundation for the main object of the pitch exercise. The commissioning of a real video game/film/TV series would be significantly determined by projected financial profit. The students are asked to comment on this issue and make a case for the potential popularity and marketability of their product. But the most important issue for them to address is what I term its intellectual profit. Building on Hatcher's arguments about the value of fiction, and the scholarship about modern representations of the Middle Ages, they must explain what their video game/film/TV series would help the audience to understand about the Middle Ages which would not be possible in a traditional historical format (i.e. a book). This is partly a matter of what they decide to include in terms of content, the choices that they make between different versions of events or accounts of individuals' motivations which they find in their initial research into the topic. But it is also a matter of discussing the potential of their chosen form and genre to convey the Middle Ages with verisimilitude.¹³ Hence, while the students must draw on their knowledge of both primary sources and secondary debate in devising their pitch, they can use the end product to 'flesh out' that material in whatever fashion they like, provided it fulfils the brief of offering some form of intellectual profit as I defined it. Having spent much of the module analysing the mediated nature of medieval history, the students must consider how their own version of the Middle Ages will be mediated, and to what purpose.

The Pitch in Action

Given the focus of this volume, my analysis here focuses on the video games which students have pitched, rather than examples of films and TV shows which they have produced. But, arguably, video games are of particular value to this exercise because of the potential for historical engagement and agency which they offer. Unlike the narrative of a film or TV show, the narrative of a game can be directly manipulated and configured by the player, to a greater or lesser extent, which allows for the playing out of alternative scenarios and which can affect the overall outcome of the main storyline (Chapman 2016, 30–33, 48–50).

Witcher 3: Wild Hunt (2015) provides an excellent example of this within a medieval action RPG. The main character through whom players experience the game, Geralt of Rivia, interacts with a number of NPCs as part of the gameplay. Decisions taken by Geralt/the player during the course of these interactions affect the subsequent course of the narrative, and there are over 30 possible different endings to the game as a result.¹⁴ Those students who choose a game for their pitch are always experienced gamers themselves and thus already aware of these possibilities. This experience is enhanced by introducing them to the burgeoning scholarship on games and history (e.g. Chapman 2016; Chapman, Foka, and Westin 2017). Amidst this there is relatively little scholarship focused specifically on medieval games. *Digital Gaming Re-imagines the Middle Ages*, edited by Daniel T. Kline, still constitutes the most substantial published exploration (Kline 2014). There are also some individual essays and articles on medieval games published elsewhere (e.g. Servitje 2014).¹⁵ The important work of Adam Chapman is especially drawn to the students' attention. His article 'Privileging Form over Content: Analysing Historical Video games' is set as compulsory reading for its cogent introduction to the status of video games as history, and for its emphasis on interrogating form rather than content when considering how they represent the past (Chapman 2012).¹⁶

The students must also read Robert Houghton's engaging account of his involvement with *Crusader Kings II* (2012–2018). A medieval historian himself, Houghton states a case for the value of fiction which parallels Hatcher's contentions: 'The ability to resort to fiction to fill in the gaps in the historical database (albeit in a realistic manner) allows the creation of a more complete world than is possible solely through the use of the sources, which is absolutely essential for the game to work' (Houghton 2014). In a talk delivered in October 2018 Houghton also highlights the potential for games to augment academic study.¹⁷ Rather than academic history being used to inform games, he argues instead for the ways in which games could inform research. In this respect games are not conceived as the end point of historical investigation but as part of its process. Houghton's contentions here provide a very useful framework within which students who pitch a video game can position their product. The range of available scholarship on historical video games is invaluable in helping the students to shape their existing experience and understanding of such games in intellectual and pedagogical terms, as required by the assessment. Over the years of teaching this module the majority of students have shown a very good if not excellent understanding of the aim of exercise, displaying high levels both of creativity and effort in their pitches. As a whole they have exceeded my expectations in demonstrating the potential of video games as a medium for representing authentic versions of the Middle Ages and enabling engagement with medieval history.

Examples

The first example was created by a student who took the module the first year that it ran, so had no previous examples for guidance.¹⁸ But his was one of the best which I have seen across the years the module has been running. He pitched a video game based on the action-adventure series *Grand Theft Auto* (1997–2013) and similar games such as *Red Dead Redemption* (2010) and *Saints Row* (2006–2013).¹⁹ It is notable that students frequently choose this style of open world game as their model, recognising its potential as a means of exploration and encounter outside the central plot, thus enabling more comprehensive coverage of their chosen subject matter. This student overlaid the framework of these games very successfully onto a Viking setting to create a game which he entitled *Grand Theft Longboat*. The gameplay revolved around a protagonist called Stybjörn, a Viking warrior operating in late tenth century and early eleventh century England during the reign of Æthelred the Unready. The king features as one of the game's main villains, as does the Danish king Sweyn Forkbeard. Stybjörn runs missions for his father Eric, including thefts, assassinations and destruction of property, based on episodes from Icelandic sagas in combination with accounts of historical events such as the St Brice's Day Massacre of the Danes in England in 1002, ordered by King Æthelred. The overall objective of the game is for Stybjörn to gain power for his own family at the expense of the two kings. The student also drew on studies of later uses and representations of the Vikings to provide a rationale for making sagas the basis of his game. He noted that these literary narratives written in the thirteenth century have often been applied to analysis of Viking activities in earlier centuries, despite the methodological problems with such an approach. Yet, regardless, heroic saga-style Vikings are still the predominant popular image of them today, despite the efforts of some scholars to challenge this characterisation (Coupland 2003). The student also examined the great popularity of Vikings as a subject for films and considered the various explanations for this phenomenon (Harty 2011). This research informed and enhanced his appreciation of the sagas themselves as a form of entertainment and escapism for their original thirteenth-century audiences. Thus the game would help players to understand why later generations commemorated their Viking ancestors in this way.

Other students have also used their pitches to examine the interplay between aspects of individuals and events generally accepted as historically verifiable, as opposed to those elements which appear in later more fictionalised accounts. One student took this approach via the medium of a game called *Hanged, Drawn OR Quartered*, which explored the history of William Wallace (ex. 1305), the Scottish knight who became famous as a leader of resistance against English attempts to establish rule over Scotland in the late thirteenth and early fourteenth centuries. This

was a graphic adventure video game, involving puzzle solving within a narrative frame. The student noted the popularity of this genre in the 1990s then a lull in its popularity prior to a resurgence of popularity, using the example of the *Broken Sword* franchise (1996–2006, 2013–14) and the *Game of Thrones* graphic adventure game (2014). The student's game focused on a young bard seeking to tell Wallace's story in the wake of his capture and imprisonment in 1305. In the course of the game the bard interacts with Wallace himself, as well as with Wallace's supporters and enemies to discover the course of events leading to Wallace's imprisonment and execution. For its content the game drew on both contemporary accounts of Wallace and the various later traditions surrounding him (Wallner 2003). These included the influential later fifteenth-century poem about Wallace written by Blind Harry, and *Braveheart* (1995), Mel Gibson's multi-award-winning but controversial film, which drew heavily upon the poem for its characterisation of Wallace. The student discussed the emphasis in graphic adventure video games on dialogue and choosing between different options, leading to a range of final outcomes. He explained that this format allowed the player to explore how and why variant narratives of Wallace's character, motivations and actions have emerged over the centuries and the uses to which these have been put.

Another student pitched an adventure RPG along the lines of *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim* (2011) and *Dragon Age: Inquisition* (2014) with St George as the main protagonist. The game was called *The Golden Legend*, a name taken from William Caxton's 1483 publication of the same name. This work constitutes an English translation of the most popular medieval compendium of saints' lives. The account of St George which it contains dramatises not only the dragon-slaying episode but also his refusal to renounce Christianity, his subsequent martyrdom and the miracles performed by his relics. Thus playing the game revealed that in the Middle Ages there was much more to St George than his combat with the dragon, the only element of his legend with which most people are familiar today. In addition the student explained that part of the objective in playing as St George was to probe the historical value of a fictional character, given that the life of St George is essentially legendary rather than a record of the exploits of a real individual. This accounted for her use of *Skyrim* and *Dragon Age* as models; these are games whose setting is a fantasy version of the Middle Ages, rather than being based on a specific historical setting. She pointed out that, although not historically real, St George was, nonetheless, a very real individual to his medieval devotees. The game therefore highlighted to the player aspects of late medieval society upon which the representation and cult of St George sheds light, in particular the ethos of chivalry and developing notions of Englishness (Good 2009).

Influenced by Hatcher several students have used their pitches to highlight that games have particular potential from the methodological

perspective of ‘history from below’. They provide a means of elaborating the experiences of those individuals and groups who are not well served by conventional historical sources and narratives. One of the best examples of such an approach was an action RPG *Antioch: Searching for Salvation*. Drawing inspiration from *Skyrim* and *Fallout: Las Vegas* (2010), this student’s game was set during the First Crusade (1096–1099). While the most famous participants were the noble leaders such as Godfrey of Bouillon and Bohemond of Taranto, the social make-up of the First Crusade was socially diverse (Kostick 2008). Thus the student’s game was conceived as a means of recreating the experience of an ‘ordinary crusader’. Antioch was chosen as a location because of the narrative possibilities offered by events there between October 1097 and June 1098, as described by a number of contemporary chroniclers (Tyerman 2004, 143–245). These include sieges, battles, starvation, cannibalism and the discovery of the spear which had pierced the side of Christ at the Crucifixion, so some crusaders believed (but not all, significantly). As the student put it in his logline for the game: ‘the decisions you choose to make, alliances you choose to form and the regions you choose to explore offer an insight into the opportunities and trials that the peasant crusader would have experienced.’

Along similar lines a number of students highlighted the potential of games to explore the possible priorities and motivations of individuals; to arrive at a conjectural yet valid understanding of their inner psyche. As with the previous game, this approach is especially useful when considering lower status people and others upon whom sources shed only a dim and oblique light. But it is also applicable to the most visible medieval figures of all: kings and queens, and other high-status individuals. Chronicles often provide detailed assessments of their appearance, character and actions. But these were only sometimes, and not often, written by people who knew them well. Thus we must question the extent to which such accounts can reliably tell us about an individual’s self-perception, beliefs and priorities. Historians must often therefore attempt to extrapolate such elements of their personality from their actions (Aird 2008, 1–21). Hence contrasting cases can be made for what such individuals were ‘really’ like, sometimes from varying interpretations of the same sources (Lewis 2013).

When focussing on a specific high-status individual, games offer the opportunity to trace the processes by which particular events unfolded and the impact of these upon their fate and reputation. This includes the imaginative working out of alternative outcomes, had different decisions been taken. Therefore, perhaps unsurprisingly several students have recognised the potential of Richard III, the most controversial English king of all, as the focus for a video game along these lines. Notable among these was the game pitched by a student who formulated an action RPG about Richard III inspired by the *Fable* series (2004–2017) and the *Mass Effect*

series (2007–2017), in order to allow players to, as his tagline stated: ‘Shape the legend’. The object is to play through Richard’s life and take decisions in response to a range of events, experiences and interactions in order to experience something of the nature of medieval rule. The student explained that a key focus was the events of April to July 1483 which saw Richard move from apparently arranging the coronation of his nephew Edward V to claiming that Edward was illegitimate and that he himself was the rightful king of England. Historians continue to differ on how best to interpret Richard’s actions in these months and these debates fed into the game (Horrox 2013). The player also learns both how Richard’s personality may have informed the choices which he made, and how his personality was formed by such choices. The game also sheds light on how this affected the perception which others had of Richard at the time, and his subsequent reputation and, in particular, the role which different beliefs about the fate of the Princes in the Tower play within this (Pollard 1995). The student argued that the player therefore probes the crucial issue of Richard’s subjectivity which is essentially absent from existing primary sources. All this was explored very effectively in visual terms within the game; as in *Fable*, Richard’s appearance was designed to change and develop in response to decisions. Thus, depending on the player’s choices this would render Richard either the embodiment of glamorous kingship or physically monstrous with the hunchback made notorious by Shakespeare.

Conclusion

Thus I have found this module to be a very successful and productive means of approaching primary sources and historiographical debate, by giving students the opportunity to take an imaginative yet methodologically justifiable approach to the analysis of these. The pitch element of the assessment allows them to exercise greater initiative and autonomy than my previous more conventional module did. It also enhances key transferable skills, especially relating to critical thinking, evaluation of evidence, project management and communication. In addition the module feedback from students is consistently very positive in terms of what students feel they have gained both intellectually, and in terms of enjoyment. To give just one example of a student comment: ‘This module represented a very creative way to look at history. . . . The pitch and essay are also a really different way of being assessed and make it a lot more fun.’ Unpicking the genesis, form and function of sources produced during the Middle Ages enables the students to gain a better understanding of the processes by which the medieval past was recorded. Moreover, the epistemological issues underpinning the module, especially the ‘fictional’ approach advocated by Hatcher, require the students to ruminate on the limitations of empirical approaches to reconstructing that past.²⁰ As the

earlier examples demonstrate, students have used the pitch to formulate video games which inventively utilize a combination of primary sources, historiographical debate and specific game formats. The games they have created thereby plausibly ‘fill in the gaps’ of our knowledge and understanding of specific medieval individuals, events and themes in ways that cannot be achieved by conventional academic monographs. Thus the module also highlights the pedagogical value of using modern narrative forms to recreate medieval events and people. Finally, and arguably most important of all, it gives the students a sense of intellectual ownership because at the end of the module they have produced their own piece of medieval narrative history.

Notes

1. Medieval history is offered by UK examination boards, but with the exception of the Tudors the most popular topics for A level history are drawn from the eighteenth to the twentieth century. Efforts are being made to encourage more teachers to include medieval history at both GCSE and A level, spear-headed by the Historical Association (2018). This issue is also discussed by Elliott in this volume.
2. Robert Houghton is currently undertaking research into the impact of modern media on undergraduate perceptions of history (see Houghton, n.d.).
3. The module is available to students taking the BA in History and also those taking joint degrees in English and History, History and Politics and History and Film. Occasionally students from elsewhere in Europe attending Huddersfield as part of the Erasmus programme have also taken this module. It is a 20-credit module and encompasses 12 weeks of teaching.
4. The Public Medievalist website is highlighted to students as important forum here. Its various blog posts introduce them to a range of conceptual approaches to modern representations and appropriations of the Middle Ages. Of particular importance are the recent special series on ‘Race, Racism and the Middle Ages’ and on ‘Gender, Sexism and the Middle Ages.’ www.publicmedievalist.com/, accessed 28 March 2019.
5. The pitch element was inspired by the assessment strategy for a module created by my colleague Patricia Cullum on gender, community and identity in the Middle Ages, which requires the students to present a 10-minute pitch for a TV or radio documentary on a topic relevant to the module’s subject.
6. For further discussion of the Global Middle Ages as both a subject of study and a methodology, see Holmes and Standen (2018).
7. The pitches are delivered after the 12 weeks of teaching are complete and are also filmed for external moderation. Sometimes students’ circumstances mean that it is not appropriate for them to deliver the pitch in front of the whole group, in which cases I make alternative arrangements with them. Most students choose to deliver the pitch individually, but they are given the option of working in a pair with a friend if they wish, in which case they are given 15 minutes for their presentation.
8. The supporting materials are all submitted electronically to dedicated assessment areas within our virtual learning environment.
9. There is a large scholarship exploring the shift from positivist to postmodernist approaches to history; for a lucid discussion especially relevant to the concerns of my module and this chapter, see Kapell and Elliott (2013, 1–10).

10. The term ‘chronicle’ technically refers to a particular kind of chronological record of events, but as Chris Given-Wilson explains, it has become accepted usage to apply the term to ‘any work the subject-matter of which claimed to be essentially historical, whether that meant events in the past or events contemporary with the time at which the author wrote’ (Given-Wilson 2004, ix).
11. For detailed discussion of the meanings of ‘truth’ to medieval chroniclers, see Given-Wilson (2004, 1–10).
12. A more or less precise dividing line between ‘factual’ and ‘fictional’ content was sometimes drawn by chroniclers, but not always and often becomes a matter of opinion from a modern critical perspective as a result.
13. My use of verisimilitude in discussions with the students has been much influenced by Kempshall (Kempshall 2011, 348–49); see also Kapell and Elliott (2013, 13–15) on videogames presenting an authentic if not accurate version of the past and the value of this for engaging students.
14. With thanks to my husband Graeme Neath for helpful discussion of the range of narrative possibilities offered by *Witcher 3*.
15. As yet there is no single-authored monograph on medieval games, although see Cooper (2016). The Public Medievalist’s specialist series on Medievalism in Games had just been launched at the time of writing: www.publicmedievalist.com/intro-games/, accessed 28 March 2019.
16. Those who choose to pitch a videogame are subsequently directed to read Chapman’s monograph to delve further into these issues.
17. The talk was given at the Interactive Pasts Conference 2 and is available online. It is ‘set watching’ for the students (Houghton 2018). See also Houghton (2019).
18. The individual students whose work I discuss here have been anonymised, but all of them gave me verbal permission to showcase their work in this chapter. I would like to thank them and all the students who have taken ‘History and Myth’ over the years for lucid, instructive and entertaining discussions of the issues explored in this chapter. Note that in what follows I have given only one or two examples of the range of scholarship which the students consulted in devising their games.
19. Dates of videogame franchises given here reflect the fact that this pitch was created in 2013.
20. Another important piece of scholarship exploring these issues which the students are directed to read is McSheffrey (2008).

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